

Problem Statement:

- Finding the right college roommate can be challenging because students often don't know who they will be living with beforehand. While some may have met their roommate online or through social media, they might not know them very well. Additionally, a person's online description or profile may differ from their real-life personality, making it difficult to predict compatibility and avoid potential conflicts.

Who is experiencing the problem?

- This problem primarily affects incoming college freshmen, who are often assigned roommates without knowing them well. Nearly everyone has either experienced or heard of the “nightmare roommate” — someone who starts conflicts, is messy, rude, or even has habits like loud snoring that make living together difficult. These challenges can make the first year of college stressful and impact students' overall experience.

What is the problem?

- The current roommate matching system is outdated and does not reflect modern social interactions. While students technically have the ability to contact their future roommates, the system is more like email than a social-media-style platform, so communication is not intuitive or encouraged. Furthermore, there is no opportunity for in-person interaction before move-in day, meaning students do not truly get to know each other until they are living together. This can lead to mismatched roommates and an uncomfortable first-year experience.

Where does the problem present itself?

- The problem arises in the context of college housing, particularly for first-year students who are assigned roommates without prior meaningful interaction. It presents itself during the move-in process, when students are suddenly living with someone they may not know well, and throughout the first weeks of school as they navigate shared living spaces. The lack of prior communication or in-person meetings can lead to misunderstandings about habits, cleanliness, schedules, and personal boundaries. Essentially, the problem is most evident whenever students are expected to live together comfortably without any structured way to assess compatibility beforehand.

Why does it matter?

- Roommate compatibility has a significant impact on a student's quality of life during their first year of college. A bad roommate can make or break the freshman experience, creating stress and discomfort during a critical period of adjustment. Conversely, having a roommate who is not only compatible but also a genuine friend can greatly enhance the college experience, fostering a positive living environment and removing a major source of anxiety for students navigating a time of extreme change.